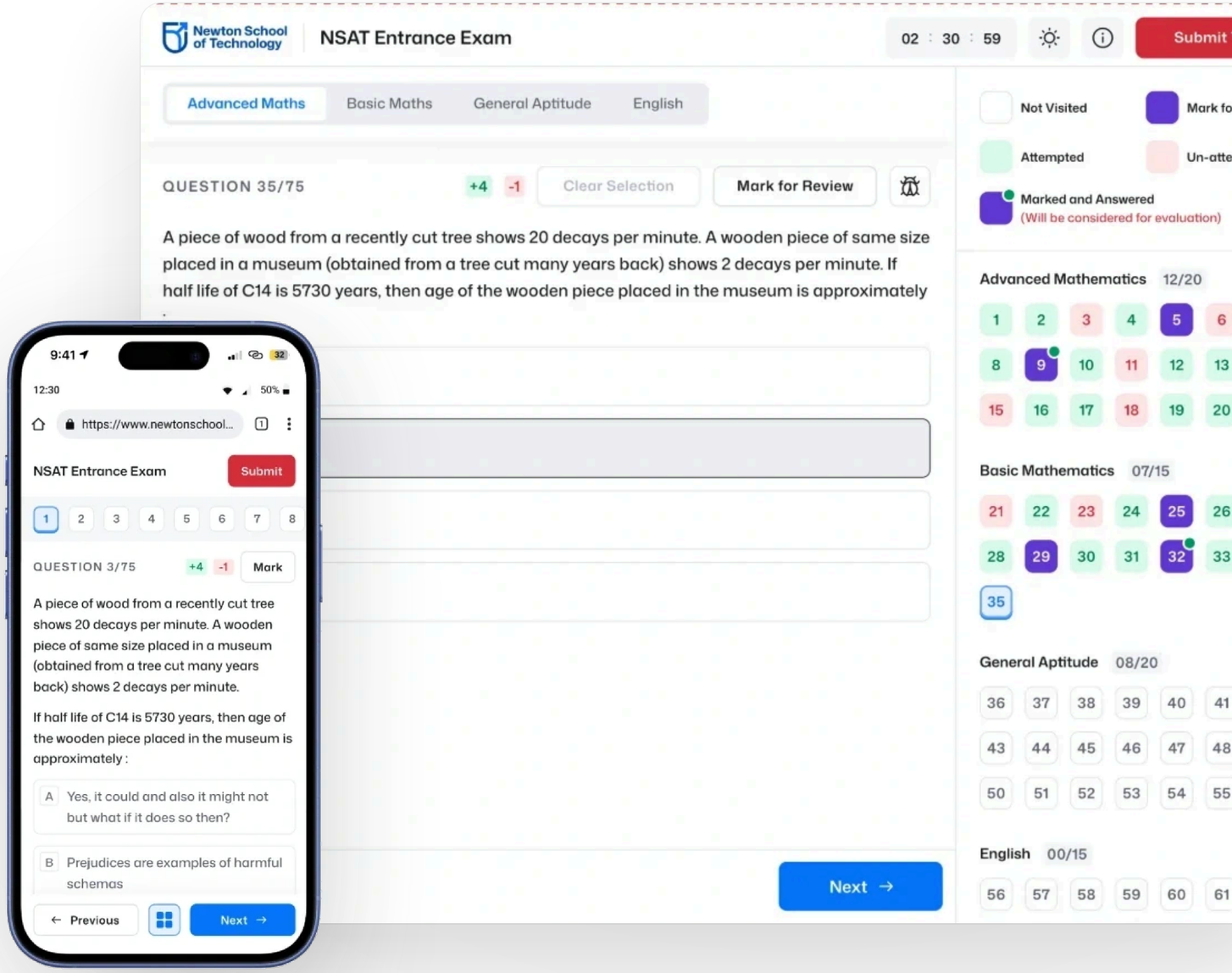
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Newton School of Technology

Growth Season 2025–26

Product design, growth systems, and the first high-stakes product experience.

Gaurav Kumar
Senior Product Designer



The big picture

The season was a system, not a campaign.

Discovery
Brand, website

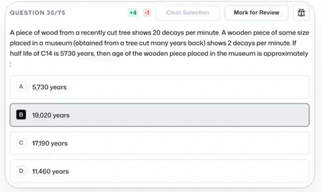
Acquisition products
Study Buddy, Head Start, referral

Signup
Account

Application
Application page

Payment
NSAT fee

Exam
NSAT / NSET



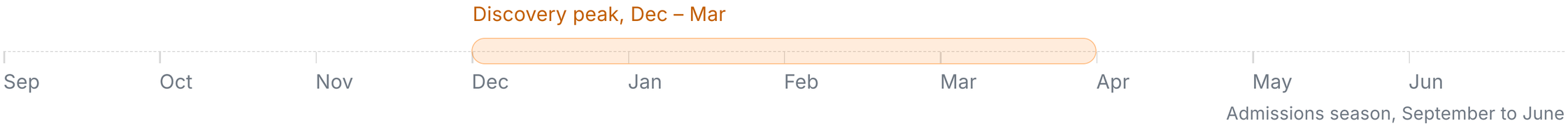
Act I
Building the growth system
Brand, website, acquisition products, referral and the steps to payment.

Act II
Redesigning the exam experience
The first prolonged product experience.

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The student journey

A high-intent journey with many handoffs.



01
Discovery
Website
Study Buddy
Head Start
Referral

02
Signup
Account creation

03
Application form
Application page
Notification centre

04
NSAT payment
Exam fee
Retries

05
Exam
NSAT / NSET interface

Campuses **Delhi** **Pune** **Bengaluru** **Hyderabad**

Every handoff is a place a student can drop out.

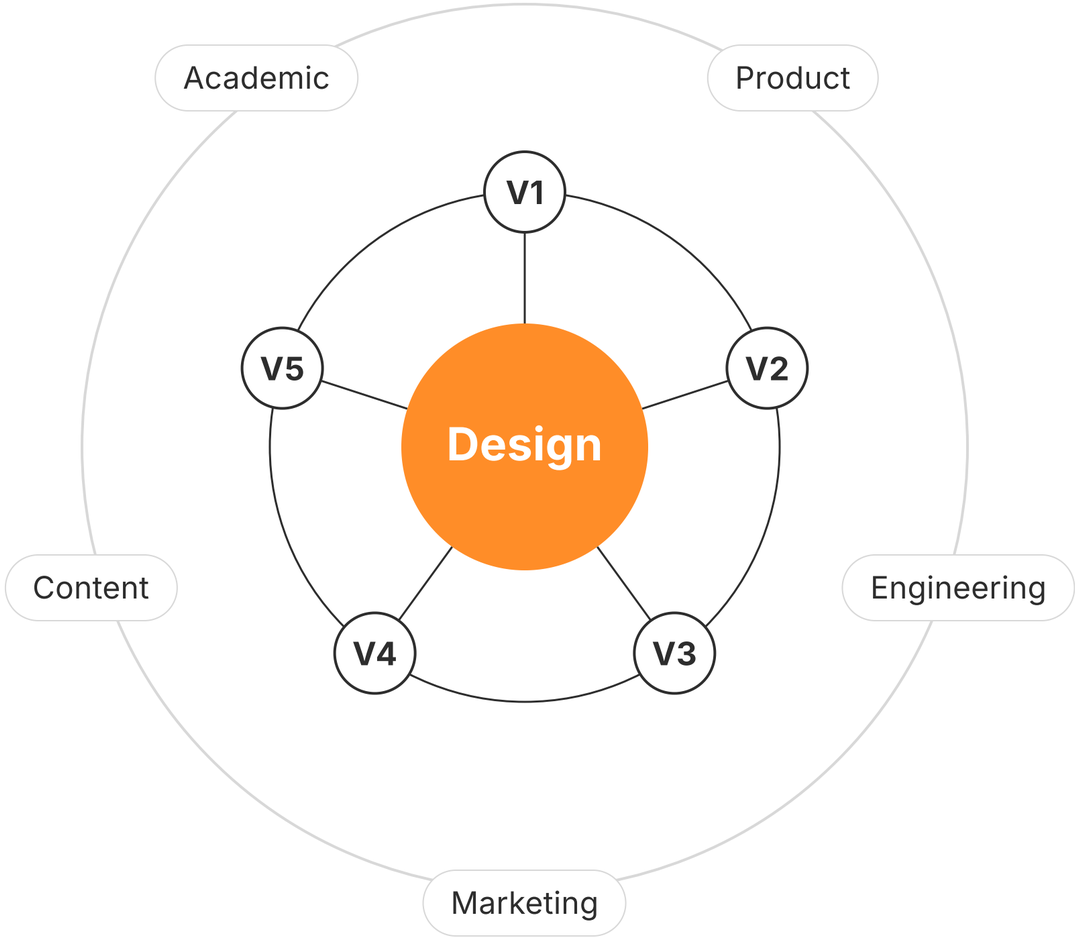
gk.

Building the design function

Five verticals. One design function.

0 → team

There was no design team when I joined. I built and led one, working across five business verticals.



Brand standardisation · September 2025

First, create one recognisable brand.

Logo

Newton School of Technology

Colour

#004599

#0673F9

Blues sampled from the logo

Typography

Illustrative

Aa

Headline

Body copy for campaigns

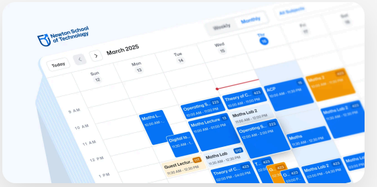
CAPTION · LABEL

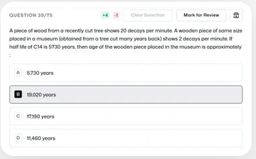
Photography

Illustrative

One crop, light and colour treatment across campuses

Product screenshots





Central brand portal

- Logos
- Colours
- Typography
- Photography
- Product screenshots

One source for campus and central teams

Board recreated for this presentation. Logo, colours and product screenshots are real; typography and photography tiles are illustrative.

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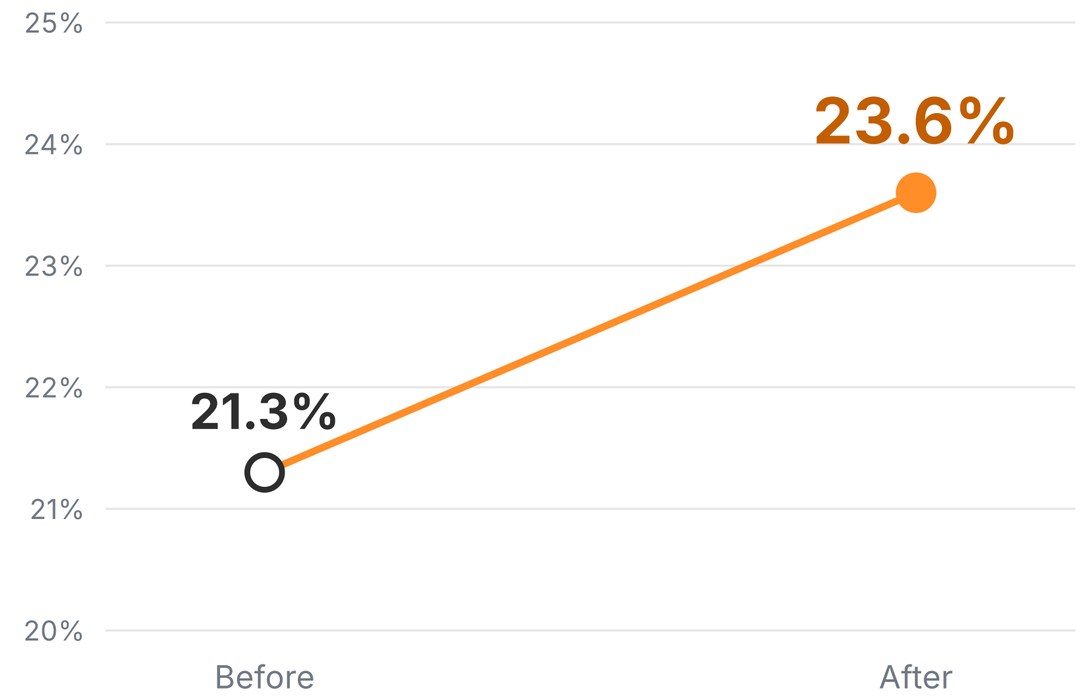
Website redesign

21 days. 18 pages. A measurable lift.



18 pages redesigned in **21** days

Signup conversion, before and after the redesign



+2.3 pp percentage points, at 98% confidence

A 2.3 percentage-point increase in signup conversion (21.3% → 23.6%), as reported with 98% statistical confidence.

Top-of-funnel products

Products created demand before application.

Study Buddy

110,589

users acquired



14.4% Study Buddy → NSAT paid

Head Start

Free coding courses

`Python` `C++` `Fundamentals`

PWA adoption

Did not add the PWA icon		**baseline**
Added the PWA icon		**+23%**

NSAT payment conversion across Study Buddy and Head Start. An observed difference, not proof of cause.

All three feed the same next step: the NSAT application and payment

gk.

Season-wide scale

The season at a glance.

≈1.75% Unique top-of-funnel acquisitions → unique payers

Derived: 15,930 ÷ 909,850

909,850 unique top-of-funnel acquisitions

15,930 unique payers

to scale: 1.75% of the bar above

20,152 payments, including retries

Transactions, not students. Not part of the funnel above.

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Referral growth

Referral became a high-intent acquisition channel.

3,468 unique users acquired through referral

1,274 paid

36.7% referral → paid conversion

+21%

Referral conversion, year over year

Relative improvement. The previous year's rate isn't shown here.

9.38% of all paid, as reported*

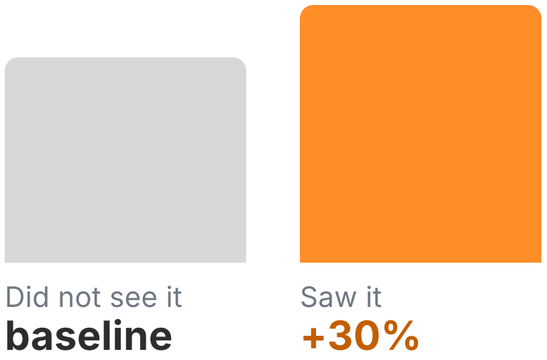
*The base for "9.38% of all paid" is being confirmed: 1,274 is 8.0% of the 15,930 unique payers.

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Improving the next step

Small experience improvements can matter deeper in the funnel.

Notification centre



Did not see it
baseline

Saw it
+30%

Relative conversion of students who saw the notification centre vs those who did not. Observed, not causal; group sizes not in the source data.

Application page

33,424 unique visitors

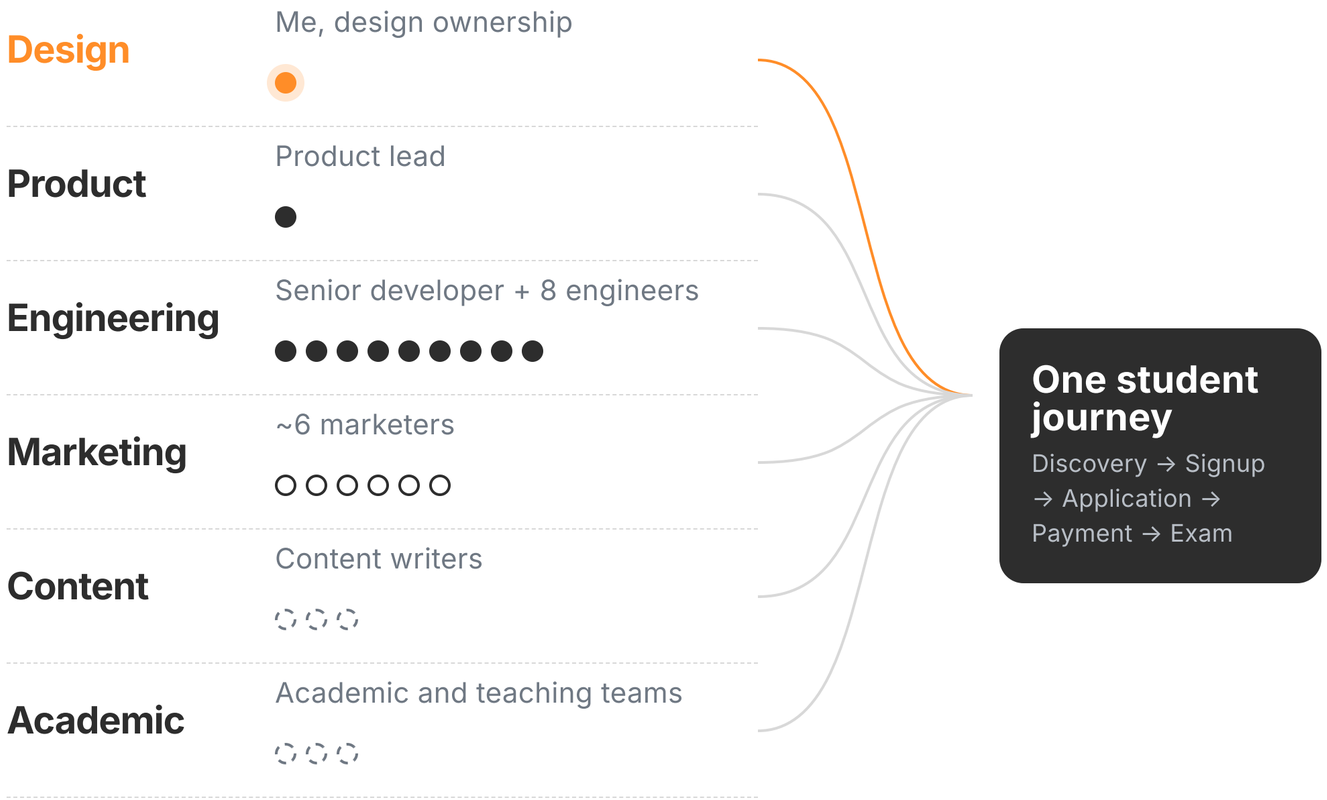
15,930 unique payers

47.7% apply → paid conversion

Cross-functional leadership

The work only moved when the system moved.

I owned design, and stayed close to funnel quality and the student experience. Every discipline shaped the same journey.

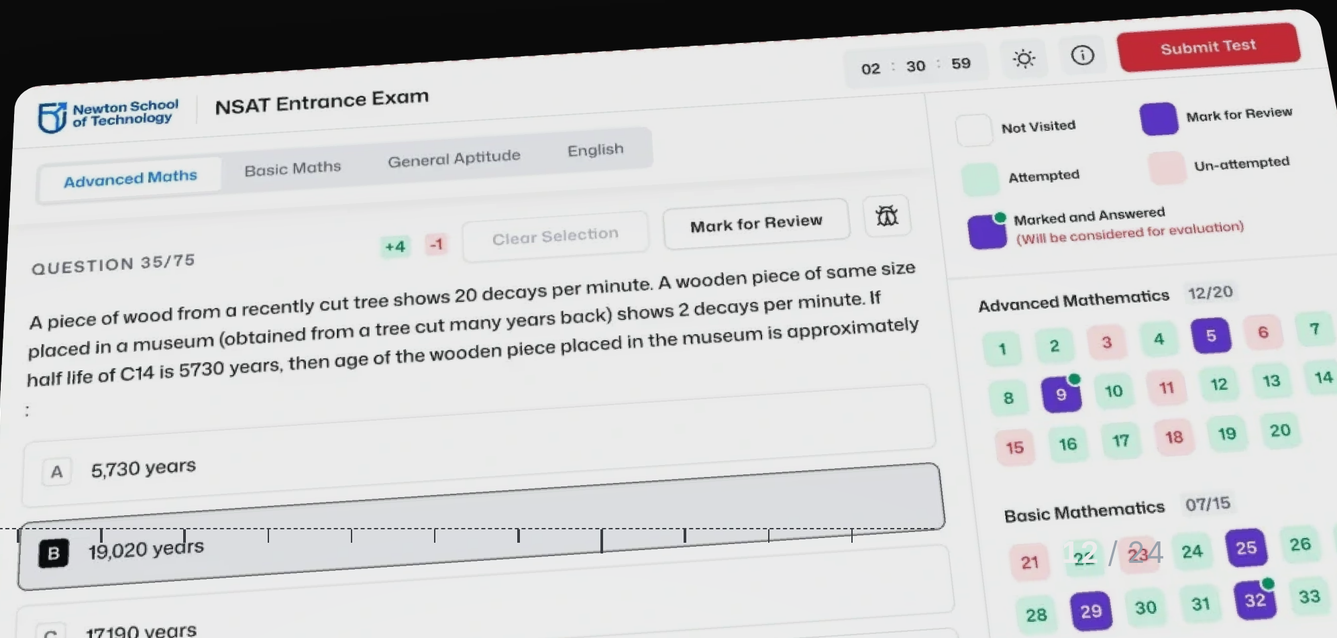


gk.

Act II · The exam interface

The first prolonged product experience was the exam.

Redesigning the NSAT / NSET exam interface.



gk.

The problem

Students were learning the interface before taking the exam.

5–6 min

a student could spend understanding how the interface worked, before answering anything

Reported

01 The interface lacked cohesion.

02 Its working had to be learned, under exam time.

03 Switching between sections meant unnecessary back-and-forth.

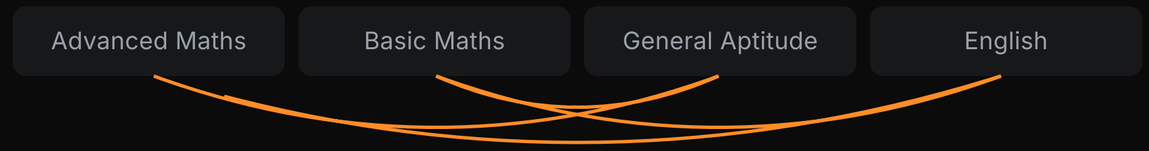


Illustration of the back-and-forth, not a screenshot

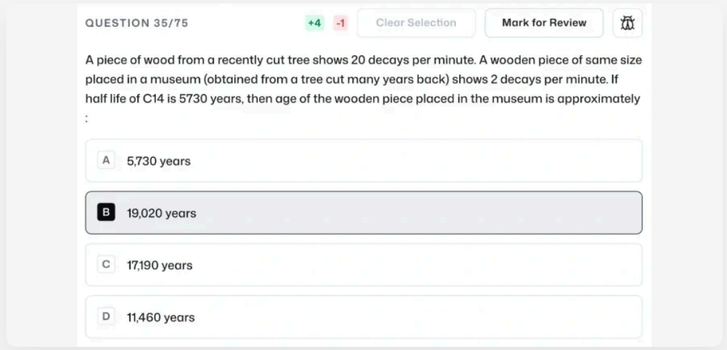
Design observations, as reported. No screenshots of the previous interface were available, so none are shown.

Design principles

Design for confidence under pressure.

1

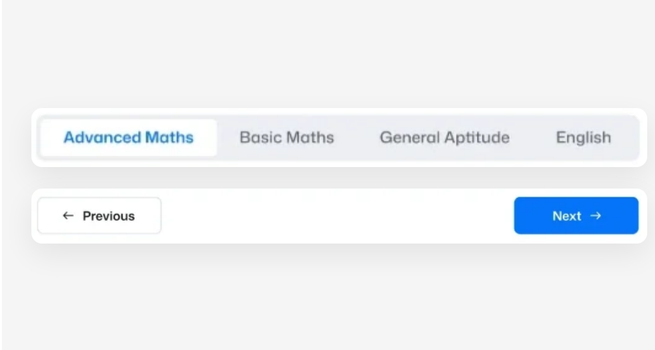
Reduce cognitive load



One question at a time. Four lettered options, and the chosen answer is filled solid.

2

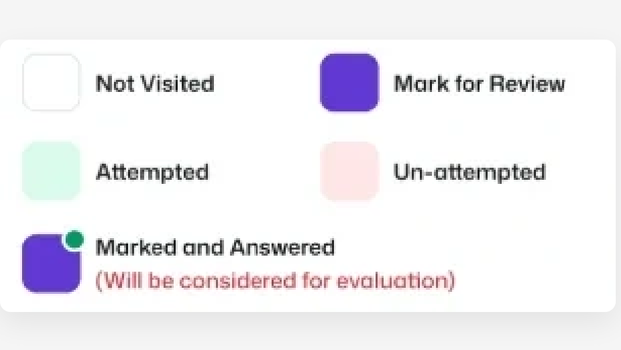
Make navigation predictable



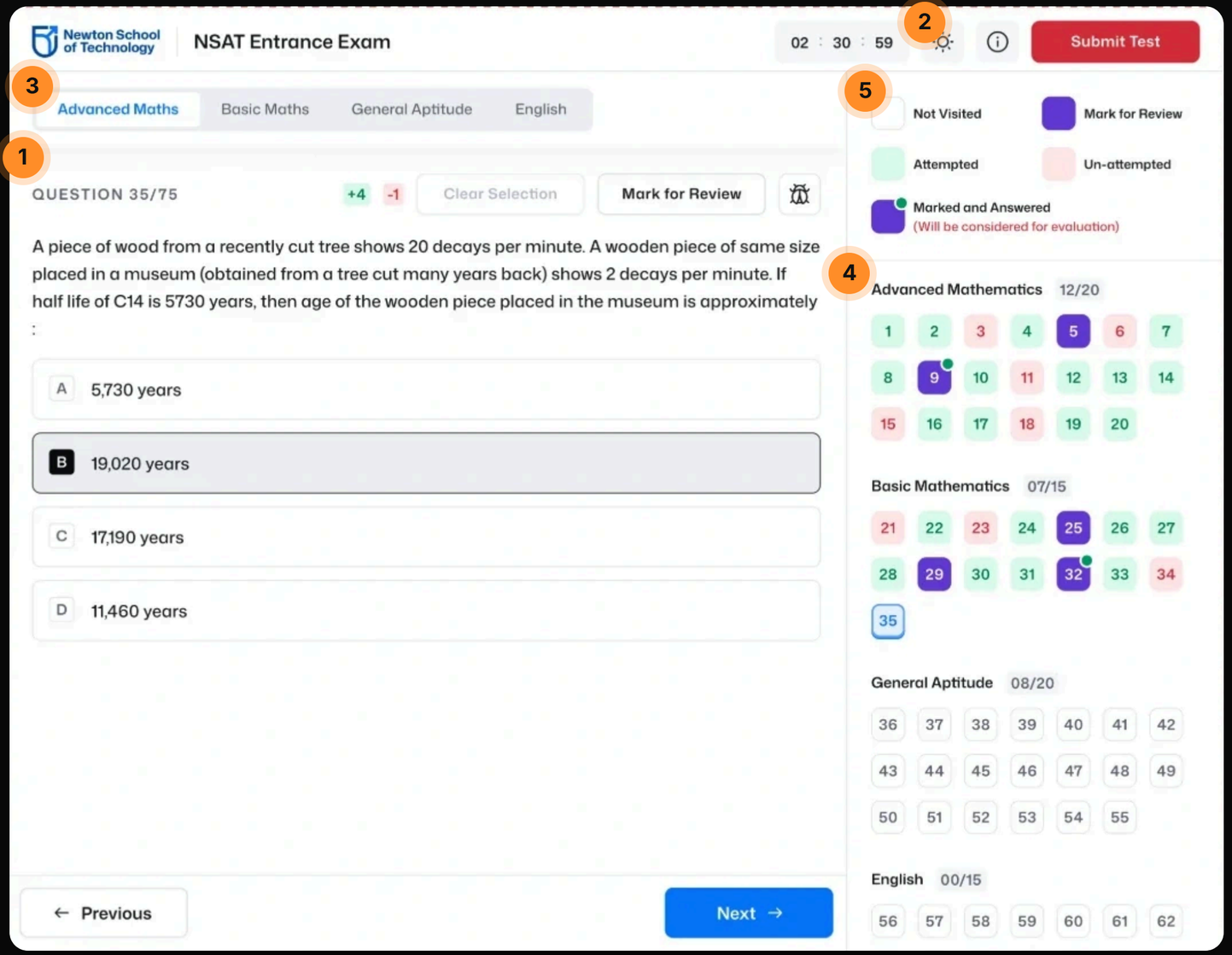
Sections are tabs. Previous and Next always sit in the same place.

3

Make progress and states clear



Every question state has its own colour and fill, explained by a legend that stays on screen.



The new exam canvas

One exam canvas. Less friction.

1. **Full-width layout**
   The question gets the width, so long questions need less scrolling.

2. **Light / dark theme toggle**
   Dark mode is there to reduce perceived glare over a long exam.

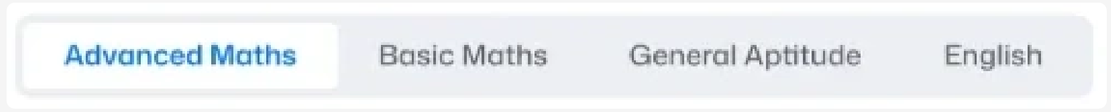
3. **Section tabs**
   Switch sections directly, in one click.

4. **Question navigation, right side**
   A collapsible panel: every question, grouped by section.

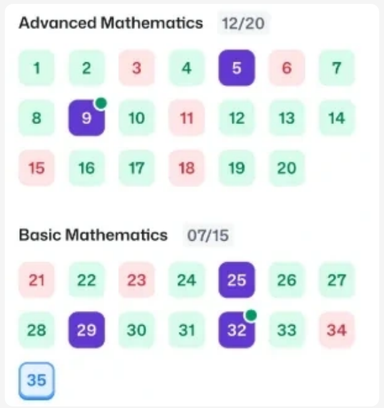
5. **Question and review states**
   Attempted, not visited, marked for review: clearer at a glance.

Navigation and question states

Move through the exam without losing your place.



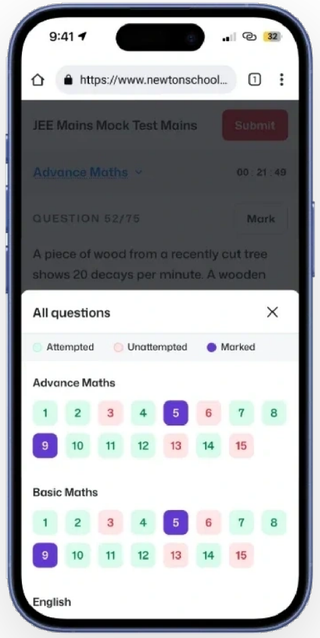
1 **Section tabs** switch sections directly. The active section is highlighted.



2 **Question navigation** gives an overview: every question by section, with a count per section (12/20, 07/15).



3 **Question states** show progress and review intent. Marked and answered questions are still evaluated.

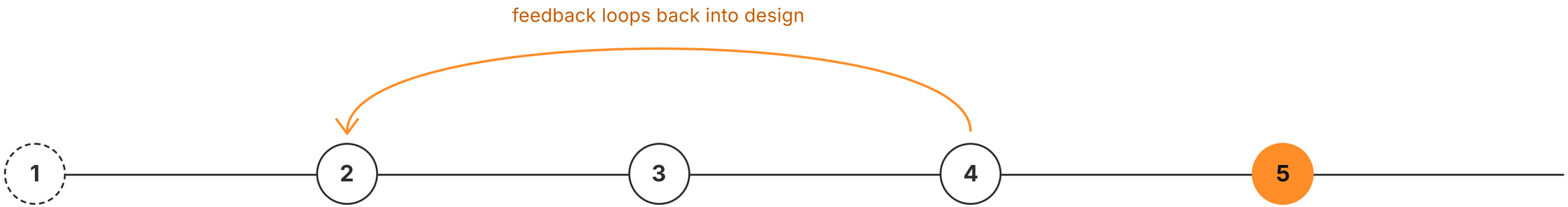


On mobile, the same overview opens as an “All questions” sheet.

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Designing with constraints

The experience had to fit the system underneath.



Constraint
Backend and storage integration

Design exploration
Internal testing informed iterations

Student feedback
Online students contacted for feedback

Iteration
Revised quiz and exam patterns tested with a small group

Launch
Wider release

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From design to shipped product

Design decisions, implemented in the real codebase.

01 · Me

Product thinking and design

Problem, principles, interface, states

02 · Me, with Claude

Implementation with codebase context

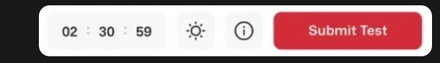


03 · Developer

Integration and shipping

~2–3 hours

04 · Live



Shipped exam interface

Implementation figures are candidate-reported. AI sped up implementation; developer integration took it to production.

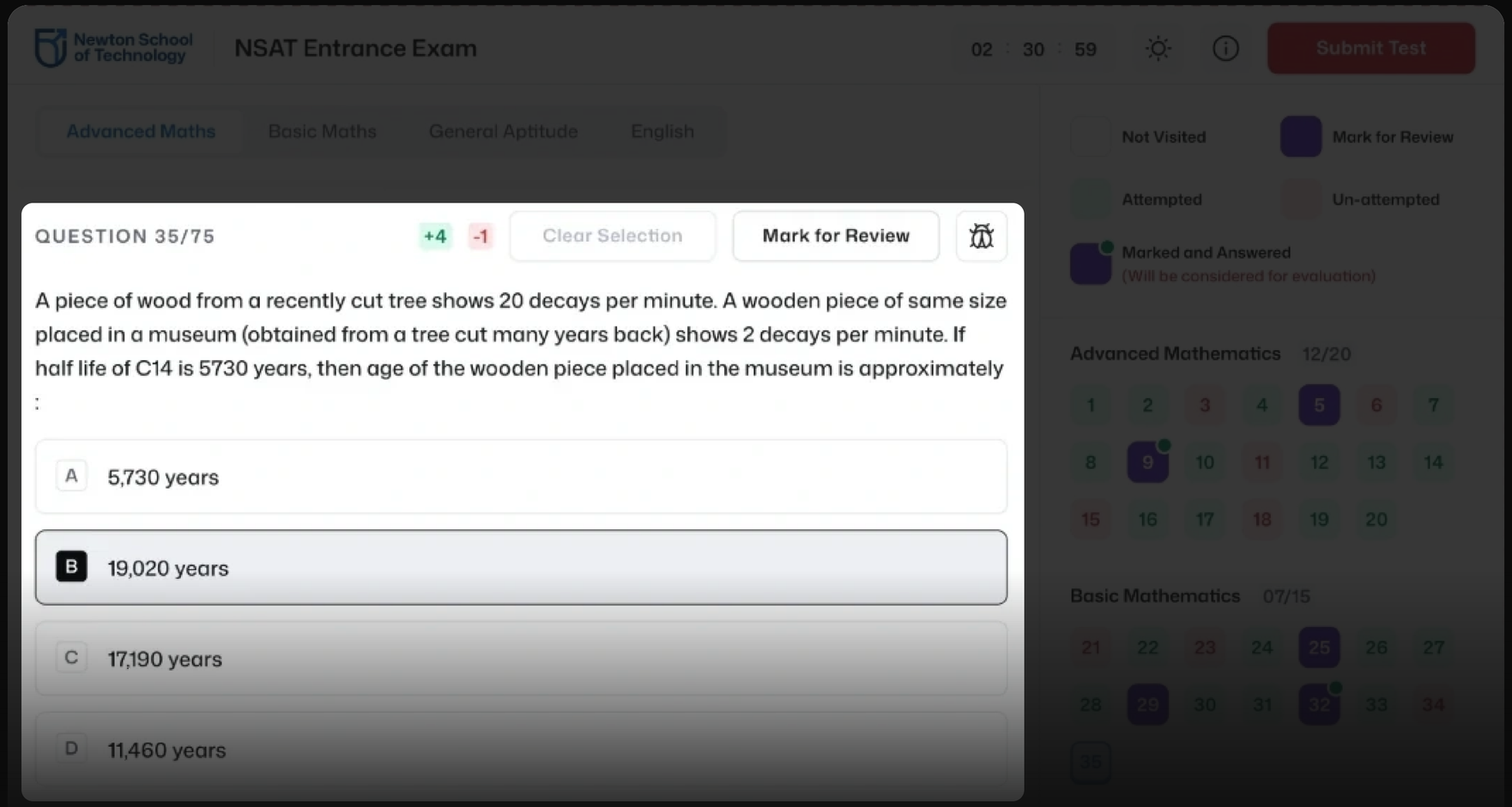
Outcome

A clearer interface. A better exam experience.

3.7 → **4.2** / 5 reported satisfaction



Reported scores out of 5. Sample size, survey question and how the score was measured are still to be verified, so this isn't presented as a controlled result.



The interface should disappear.
The exam should remain.

gk.

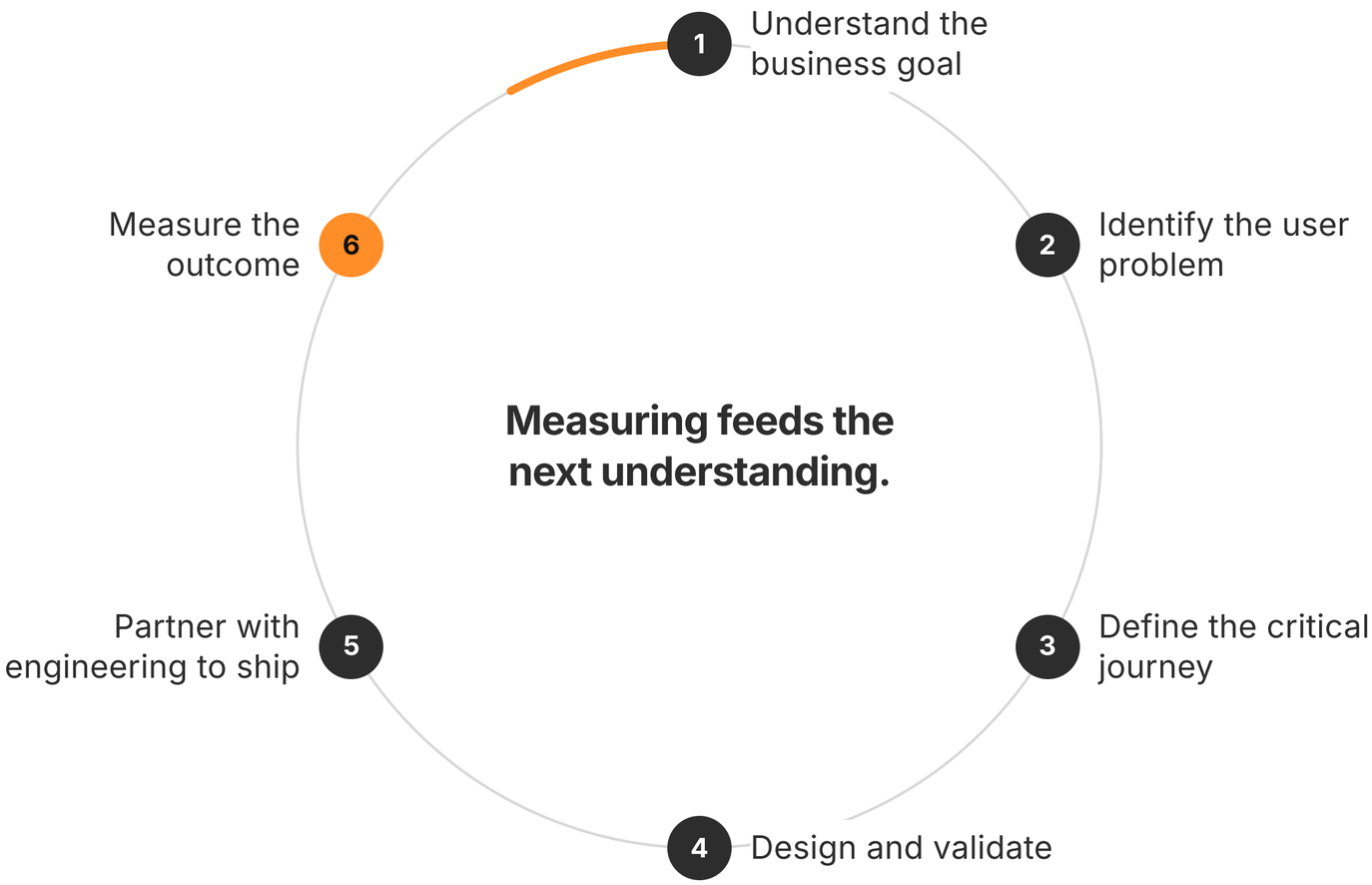
What the season taught me

Design creates leverage when it works as a system.

- **Consistency across touchpoints reduces fragmented experiences.**
  Brand system, website · slides 05–06
- **Growth means understanding the whole journey, not one conversion screen.**
  Journey, funnel, referral · slides 03, 07–10
- **High-stakes product experiences deserve careful usability work.**
  Exam interface · slides 13–20

How I approach product design

Start with the business. Stay with the user. Ship the solution.



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What I would do next

The next iteration starts with better evidence.

Proposed Future work, not completed work

First

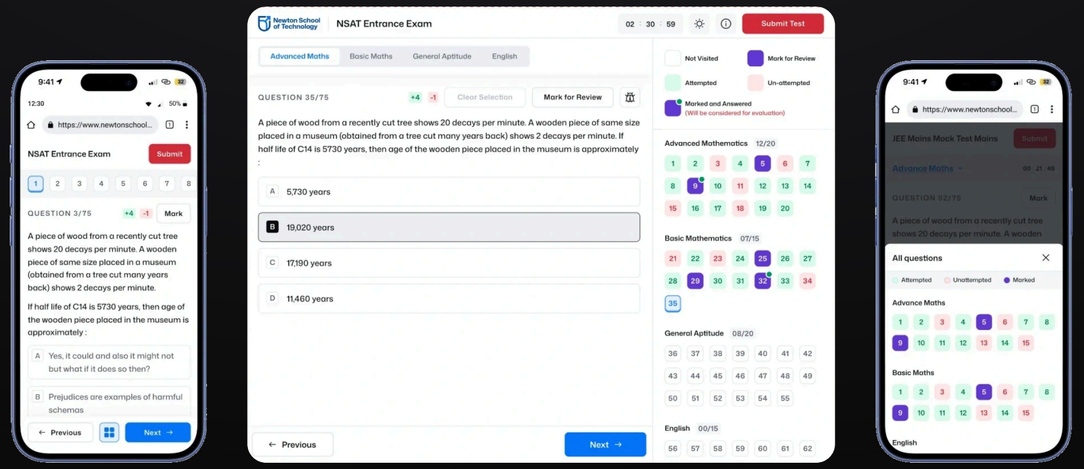
- Validate the exam satisfaction baseline and method

Then

- Measure task completion and navigation friction
- Examine performance across device types

Ongoing

- Keep testing question navigation and section switching
- Connect interface changes to student confidence and completion



Build experiences that move the business forward.

gk. Thank you.